

THE FOCUS *Reset*

7 Science-Backed
Ways to Beat Brain Fog,
Restore Your Energy &
Get More Done



HYDRATE



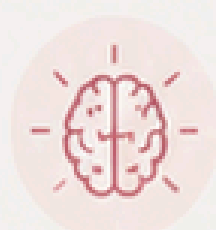
NOURISH



SLEEP



MANAGE
STRESS



SUPPORT
YOUR BRAIN



FOCUS &
GET MORE DONE



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Why You're Not as Productive as You Could Be

Have you ever sat down to work knowing exactly what you needed to do... only to realise an hour later that you've barely made any progress? You reread the same paragraph. Check your phone. Open another tab. Make another drink. Start one task, switch to another, then wonder where the time went.

It's easy to assume you need more discipline.
But productivity isn't just about discipline.

Your ability to get things done depends heavily on the state of your brain. When you're tired, dehydrated, stressed, undernourished or mentally overloaded, focusing becomes harder. You can force yourself to keep working, but more hours don't necessarily mean more meaningful work. That's why I'm a firm believer in working smarter, not harder.

Focus is your productivity superpower

Think about two very different workdays.

On the first, you're exhausted. Your mind feels foggy. You're jumping between tasks and getting distracted every few minutes. Something that should take 30 minutes somehow takes two hours.

On another day, you feel clear-headed and energised. You know exactly what matters, distractions barely register, ideas come easily and you finish the same amount of work before lunch.

Same person. Same intelligence. Same 24 hours. Completely different output.

The difference is your ability to focus.

When you can direct your attention intentionally, you can think more clearly, solve problems faster, make better decisions and complete meaningful work without spending your entire life working.

And that's important, because being busy and being productive are not the same thing.

A packed calendar isn't a measure of success. Neither is answering 50 emails, constantly checking notifications or working until midnight. Productivity is about making progress on the things that actually matter.



Stop trying to outwork an underperforming brain

This is where conventional productivity advice often falls short.

You can have the perfect planner.

You can time-block your entire day.

You can download another productivity app, write the world's most beautiful to-do list and learn every productivity technique on the internet.

But if you've slept five hours, haven't eaten properly, are dehydrated, stressed out and relying on caffeine to drag yourself through the afternoon, you're making your brain's job unnecessarily difficult.

Before asking:

“How can I force myself to do more?”

I want you to start asking:

“What does my brain need to perform better?”

That small shift in thinking can change everything.

Your focus doesn't exist in isolation

Your mental performance is influenced by several interconnected factors:

Hydration. Nutrition. Sleep. Stress. Energy. Your environment. Your habits.

Neglect one and you might barely notice.

Neglect several at once and suddenly you're wondering why you're experiencing brain fog, procrastinating on simple tasks or needing enormous amounts of motivation just to get started.

That's why there isn't one magical productivity hack in this guide.

Instead, we're going to look at 7 areas that can quietly sabotage your focus — and, more importantly, the simple changes you can make to improve them.

Some may already be working brilliantly for you.

Others might make you think:

Oh. THAT could be why.



The goal isn't to become a productivity machine

There's one more thing I want you to remember while reading this guide.
The goal isn't to squeeze every possible drop of productivity out of yourself.

The goal is to get more of the right things done with less unnecessary struggle.

Because success shouldn't require destroying your health, sacrificing your sleep or spending every waking hour working.

You don't necessarily need more hours.

You need better energy, clearer priorities and a brain that's actually ready to focus.

And that's exactly what we're going to work on.

YOUR FOCUS RESET

Before moving on, rate yourself from 1–10:

Focus: ____ /10

Energy: ____ /10

Mental clarity: ____ /10

Stress: ____ /10

Productivity: ____ /10

Keep these numbers.

At the end of your Focus Reset, we'll come back to them and see what's changed.



Focus Killer #1: You're Running on Empty

Your brain may only account for a small proportion of your body weight, but it is an incredibly demanding organ.

It needs a constant supply of energy, nutrients and water to function properly.

And yet, when life gets busy, these are often the first things we neglect. You skip breakfast because you're rushing. Forget to drink water for hours. Grab something sugary because you need energy now. Then at 3 pm, you're staring at your screen wondering why your brain has apparently clocked out for the day.

Before reaching for another coffee, it might be worth asking: Have I actually given my brain what it needs to perform?

1. Hydrate your brain

Hydration is one of the simplest places to start.

Even relatively mild dehydration can affect aspects of cognitive performance and how you feel — including alertness, concentration and fatigue. The problem is that it's surprisingly easy to forget to drink when you're focused on work.

Rather than obsessing over one perfect number, build hydration into your routine.

Try this:

- Start your morning with a glass of water.
- Keep water visible while you work.
- Drink regularly throughout the day rather than trying to catch up at night.
- Drink more when you're exercising, sweating heavily or spending time in hot weather.
- Pay attention to thirst and urine colour as practical hydration cues.

Your individual requirements vary with body size, diet, activity, climate and other factors, so more isn't automatically better.



THE 500 ML EXPERIMENT

Feeling foggy?

Before assuming you need caffeine, try drinking some water and giving yourself a little time.

It's one of the easiest things to rule out — and costs practically nothing.

2. Stop riding the blood-sugar rollercoaster

Your brain requires a continuous supply of energy.

That doesn't mean you need to constantly eat sugar. Your body is very good at regulating the fuel available to your brain.

But the way you eat can influence how steady your energy and concentration feel throughout the day.

A highly refined, carbohydrate-heavy meal may leave some people feeling sleepy or hungry again relatively quickly. Skipping meals can also make concentration more difficult if you end up distracted by hunger or low energy.

Instead of chasing quick bursts of energy, aim for meals that keep you satisfied.

A simple formula is:

PROTEIN + FIBRE + HEALTHY FATS + QUALITY CARBOHYDRATES

Think:

Greek yoghurt + berries + nuts + oats

Eggs + wholegrain toast + avocado + vegetables

Lentils + quinoa + vegetables + olive oil

Tofu + brown rice + colourful vegetables + seeds

It doesn't have to be complicated.

Your lunch doesn't need to be Instagram-worthy. It needs to stop your brain declaring an emergency at 3 pm.

3. Feed your brain, not just your stomach

Calories provide energy, but your brain also relies on micronutrients and other dietary components to function normally.

Rather than becoming obsessed with individual “brain foods”, think about nutrient density and variety.

Some particularly useful areas to pay attention to include:



Omega-3 fatty acids

Omega-3s are important components of cell membranes, including those in the brain. Plant sources include chia seeds, flaxseeds and walnuts, while EPA and DHA are found primarily in fish and algae-derived sources.

B vitamins

Several B vitamins contribute to normal energy metabolism and nervous-system function. Good dietary sources include whole grains, legumes, nuts, seeds, leafy vegetables, eggs and dairy, depending on the specific vitamin.

Iron

Iron contributes to normal cognitive function and energy metabolism. Low iron intake or deficiency can be particularly relevant when fatigue and poor concentration appear together.

Magnesium

Magnesium participates in hundreds of biochemical reactions and contributes to normal nervous-system function and energy metabolism. Nuts, seeds, legumes, whole grains and leafy greens are useful sources.

Antioxidant-rich foods

Rather than searching for one miraculous antioxidant, eat plenty of colourful fruits, vegetables, herbs, spices, nuts and seeds.

The objective isn't perfection.

It's giving your brain consistently good raw materials.

4. Don't wait until you're completely depleted

One of the easiest productivity traps is treating food and water as things you'll deal with after the work is finished.

But that can become completely backwards.

You wouldn't expect your laptop to perform brilliantly at 2% battery while running twenty applications.

Don't expect that from yourself either.

If you repeatedly reach the afternoon exhausted, hungry, irritable or unable to concentrate, don't immediately assume you have a motivation problem.

Look for the pattern.

What did you eat?

When did you last eat?

How much have you drunk?

How did you feel two hours earlier?

Learning your own patterns is far more useful than blindly following someone else's "perfect" routine.



YOUR FOCUS RESET

For the next few days, don't overhaul your entire diet.

Start with three things:

01 — WATER

Keep water within reach while you're working.

02 — BUILD, DON'T RESTRICT

Instead of thinking about what you need to eliminate, ask what you can add to make your meals more nourishing and satisfying.

Can you add protein?

A handful of vegetables?

Seeds?

Fruit?

A source of healthy fat?

03 — NOTICE THE CRASH

When your focus suddenly disappears, make a quick note of the time and what you've eaten and drunk during the previous few hours.

After several days, you may start seeing patterns.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

The next time you think:

“Why can't I concentrate?”

Ask yourself first:

“Am I asking my brain to perform without giving it enough fuel?”

Sometimes the first productivity hack isn't another app, planner or complicated system.

It's lunch.



Focus Killer #2: You're Borrowing Energy

There's a reason sleep deprivation makes everything feel harder. Tasks take longer. Decisions become exhausting. You're more easily distracted. Your patience disappears. Your motivation drops — and suddenly even replying to a simple email feels like an unreasonable demand.

So what do many of us do?

We reach for caffeine.

And caffeine can absolutely make you feel more alert. But there's an important distinction:

Caffeine can temporarily reduce the feeling of tiredness. It cannot replace sleep.

If you're repeatedly using stimulants to compensate for inadequate rest, you're essentially borrowing energy from a brain that needs recovery. Eventually, the bill arrives.

I. Sleep is productive time

Sleep can feel inconvenient when you have a lot to accomplish. An extra hour awake looks like an extra hour available for work. But that's only useful if your brain performs just as well — and it doesn't.

Sleep supports attention, learning, memory, emotional regulation and decision-making. It also gives your body an opportunity to recover and prepares your brain for another day of processing information.

So sacrificing sleep to gain more working hours can become a terrible trade: More time awake. Less effective time.

Think about the difference between trying to complete an important task when you're exhausted and doing the same task after a genuinely restorative night's sleep.

You may have exactly the same number of items on your to-do list. But you don't have the same brain.

PRODUCTIVITY REFRAME

Don't think:

“I don't have time to sleep.”

Think:

“Sleep is part of tomorrow's productivity strategy.”



2. Find your sleep sweet spot

There isn't one magical bedtime that works for everyone.

What matters more is getting enough sleep consistently and working with your natural rhythm where possible.

Most adults generally need around 7–9 hours of sleep per night, although individual requirements vary.

And here's something worth paying attention to:
How you feel during the day matters.

If you're regularly waking exhausted, struggling to stay awake during the afternoon or depending on large amounts of caffeine just to function, your body may be telling you something.

Instead of immediately trying to suppress the tiredness, investigate it.

3. Make sleep easier before you need it

Good sleep doesn't begin the moment your head touches the pillow.

Your evening routine can help tell your brain:

The day is finished. It's safe to switch off.

You don't need a two-hour wellness ritual involving seventeen supplements, a silk eye mask and the moon being in exactly the right position.

Start with the basics.

Keep your sleep and wake times reasonably consistent.

Make your bedroom dark, quiet and comfortable.

Dim bright lights in the evening.

Give yourself time to wind down.

Avoid doing stimulating work right until bedtime when possible.

Be mindful of late caffeine.

And if scrolling in bed regularly turns “I'll just check Instagram for five minutes” into 1:14 am...

Your phone may need its own bedtime.



4. Stop using caffeine as an energy strategy

Caffeine is one of the most widely used shortcuts for tiredness.

And yes, it can temporarily make you feel more alert.

But feeling more awake and actually having more energy are not the same thing.

Caffeine doesn't provide your brain with energy. It primarily works by blocking the action of adenosine — one of the chemical signals involved in making you feel sleepy.

In other words, caffeine can temporarily turn down the volume on tiredness. But the reason you were tired may still be there.

Poor sleep.

Mental exhaustion.

Stress.

Inadequate nutrition.

Dehydration.

Too little recovery.

And that's why I don't believe caffeine should be the foundation of a productive day.

Don't mask the signal. Investigate it.

Tiredness isn't necessarily something you need to defeat. Sometimes it's information.

If you find yourself reaching for caffeine every time your energy drops, get curious about why your energy is dropping in the first place.

Ask yourself:

Did I sleep enough?

Have I eaten properly?

Am I hydrated?

Have I been staring at a screen for four hours without moving?

Am I mentally overloaded?

Do I actually need a break?

Fixing the underlying problem may do far more for your productivity than temporarily masking the symptom.



5. The caffeine trap

There's another problem.

Caffeine can stay in the body for many hours, and consuming it later in the day can interfere with sleep — particularly if you're sensitive to it.

That can create a frustrating cycle:

Poor sleep → tiredness → caffeine → disrupted sleep → more tiredness → more caffeine

The very thing you're using to compensate for inadequate energy can potentially contribute to the problem you're trying to solve.

And caffeine isn't only found in coffee.

Tea, matcha, energy drinks, cola, pre-workouts, chocolate and even some supplements can contribute to your total intake.

If you consume caffeine regularly, it's worth asking whether it's genuinely improving your day — or whether you've simply reached the point where you need it to feel normal.

6. Build real energy instead

What if, rather than constantly asking:
“How can I make myself feel more awake?”

you started asking:
“How can I create more sustainable energy?”

That's a completely different strategy.

Sleep creates recovery.

Food provides fuel and essential nutrients.

Water supports normal physical and cognitive function.

Movement increases circulation and can help you feel more alert.

Daylight supports your circadian rhythm.

Breaks reduce mental fatigue.

Stress management helps prevent your brain from operating in permanent emergency mode.

None of these gives you the instant kick of a stimulant.

But that's exactly the point.

We're not looking for a kick. We're building a brain that doesn't constantly need one.



WHAT ABOUT COFFEE?

If you love coffee, I'm not telling you that you can never drink it again. But I am encouraging you to stop treating caffeine as a solution for inadequate sleep or chronically low energy.

Try reducing your reliance on it and pay attention to what happens.

And if you don't need caffeine?

You don't need to start.

YOUR FOCUS RESET

For the next few days, pay attention to the relationship between sleep, caffeine and energy.

01 — PROTECT YOUR SLEEP

Choose one improvement: an earlier bedtime, a consistent sleep schedule, less screen time before bed, or a better wind-down routine.

02 — QUESTION THE CAFFEINE

Every time you reach for caffeine, ask yourself:

Why am I tired right now?

Don't judge the answer. Just notice it.

03 — TRY THE ALTERNATIVE

When your energy dips, experiment with water, food, daylight, movement or a short break before reaching for stimulation.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

When your brain says:

“I need something to keep me going.”

Ask:

“What would give me real energy right now?”

Because the goal isn't to become better at pushing through exhaustion. It's to stop being exhausted in the first place.



Focus Killer #3: Your Brain Has Too Many Tabs Open

You know that feeling when your laptop has 27 tabs open, three programs running, something downloading in the background and suddenly everything starts slowing down?

Your brain can feel surprisingly similar.

An unfinished project. An email you need to answer. Something you forgot to order. Tomorrow's deadline. A conversation that's bothering you. The washing. Your finances. That appointment you need to book.

And, somehow, while you're trying to finish a spreadsheet, your brain decides it's the perfect moment to remind you of something embarrassing you said in 2019.

Welcome to mental overload.

You might think you have a focus problem.

Sometimes, you simply have too much competing for your attention.

I. Your attention has limits

Your brain is constantly deciding what deserves your attention.

That's useful when something genuinely important happens.

Not so useful when everything feels important.

When you're juggling multiple responsibilities, notifications, worries and unfinished tasks, part of your mental capacity can become occupied simply trying to keep track of everything.

The result?

You sit down to concentrate — but your brain keeps interrupting you.

Don't forget this.

What about that?

We need to deal with this later.

Maybe check your email just in case.

The solution isn't necessarily becoming more disciplined.

Sometimes you need to give your brain fewer things to hold.



2. Get it out of your head

One of the simplest tools for mental overload is also one of the most effective:

Write everything down.

Not a beautifully organised to-do list.

Not a colour-coded productivity system.

Just a brain dump.

Write down every task, thought, reminder, worry and unfinished piece of business that's occupying mental space.

Big or small.

Finish presentation.

Buy toothpaste.

Reply to Sarah.

Book dentist.

Research new supplier.

Why hasn't that person replied?

Plan next week's meals.

Once it's outside your head, you can decide what actually deserves your attention.

Your brain is brilliant at thinking.

Don't waste it on storage.

3. Everything cannot be a priority

After a brain dump, you may discover something slightly horrifying:
You have 37 things you think you should be doing.

That's okay.

The mistake is trying to treat all 37 as equally important.
Because when everything is a priority...nothing is.

Ask yourself:

What actually matters today?

Not this month.

Not eventually.

Today.

Choose your most important task — the one that would make the biggest meaningful difference if you completed it.

Then choose two other important tasks.

That's it.



YOUR TOP 3

1 — The ONE thing that matters most

2 — Important

3 — Important

Everything else can wait its turn.

This doesn't mean you're ignoring your responsibilities.

You're deciding where your attention goes first.

4. Stop confusing multitasking with productivity

Multitasking can make us feel incredibly busy.

Laptop open.

Phone beside us.

Email notifications appearing.

WhatsApp pinging.

Music playing.

Six browser tabs.

Halfway through writing something when another task suddenly seems urgent.

It feels productive because you're constantly doing something.

But for many mentally demanding activities, you're not really doing several things simultaneously.

You're switching your attention between them.

And every switch has a cost.

You have to remember where you were, reconstruct what you were thinking and get yourself back into the task.

Do that repeatedly and a piece of work that could have taken 45 focused minutes can consume half your afternoon.

SINGLE-TASKING IS A SUPERPOWER

Try giving one important task your complete attention.

One document.

One goal.

One browser window if possible.

Phone away.

Notifications off.



Finish — or reach a predetermined stopping point — before switching.
It sounds almost ridiculously simple.

That's because it is.
Simple doesn't mean easy.

5. Stress steals attention

Mental overload isn't only about having too many tasks.
Sometimes the biggest tab open in your brain isn't a task at all.

It's stress.
When you're worried about something, your attention naturally keeps returning to it.
Trying to force yourself to “just stop thinking about it” rarely works.
Instead, identify what kind of problem you're dealing with.

CAN I DO SOMETHING ABOUT IT?

If yes:

What's the smallest useful action I can take?

Make the call.

Send the email.

Have the conversation.

Ask for help.

Make the decision.

Write the plan.

Taking action can transform a vague source of anxiety into a concrete problem you're dealing with.

If no:

Ask yourself whether continuing to mentally rehearse the problem is helping you.

Sometimes the productive action is not doing more.

It's accepting that something is temporarily outside your control.

6. Stress management isn't optional

Stress isn't just an unpleasant feeling you should tolerate while getting things done.

High levels of stress can interfere with attention, working memory, decision-making and emotional regulation.

And when stress becomes chronic, it can also interfere with sleep and recovery — which then feeds directly back into the problems we covered in the previous chapter.

This is why managing stress belongs in a productivity guide.

A calmer brain is often a more capable brain.



Your solution doesn't need to be complicated.

A short walk.

Slow breathing.

Meditation.

Exercise.

Journaling.

Time outdoors.

Talking to someone.

Taking a genuine break.

Even stopping for a few minutes and asking:

“What exactly am I stressed about?” can be surprisingly useful.

You can't eliminate every stressful situation from your life.

But you can become much better at noticing when stress is controlling your attention.

7. Stop trying to solve your entire life today

Sometimes overwhelm comes from looking at everything simultaneously.

You don't just think:

I need to finish this project.

You think:

I need to finish this project, grow my business, get fitter, organise my finances, improve my relationships, eat perfectly, learn another language, sort out my house and somehow become the person I thought I'd be by now.

No wonder you don't know where to start.

Zoom in.

What's the next step?

Not the entire strategy.

Not the perfect solution.

Not the next six months.

The next useful action.

Big goals become much less intimidating when your brain only has to deal with the next step.

YOUR FOCUS RESET

Feeling mentally overloaded? Try this 10-minute reset.

MINUTES 1-3 — EMPTY YOUR HEAD

Write down everything that's currently occupying your attention.



MINUTES 4–5 — SORT

Mark each item:

DO — needs action

DECIDE — requires a decision

DELEGATE — someone else can handle it

DROP — doesn't actually need doing

MINUTES 6–7 — CHOOSE YOUR TOP 3

Pick the three things that matter most today.

Then circle one.

That's where you start.

MINUTES 8–10 — CLEAR THE NOISE

Close unnecessary tabs.

Put your phone away.

Silence notifications.

Get what you need for the task in front of you.

And begin.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

The next time you find yourself jumping between tasks, worrying about everything and accomplishing very little, ask:

“What deserves my attention right now?”

You don't need to solve everything at once.

You just need to know what matters next.



Focus Killer #4: You're Fighting Your Biology

Some days, you wake up ready to conquer the world.

Your brain is sharp. Ideas flow. You fly through your work and wonder why you ever procrastinate.

Other days?

Opening your laptop feels like a personal attack.

We often expect ourselves to have exactly the same energy, motivation and mental performance every single day.

But we're humans, not machines.

Your energy naturally fluctuates. Your circadian rhythm, sleep, hormones, activity, stress, food, recovery and even the time of day can influence how you feel and perform.

The mistake isn't having fluctuations.

The mistake is expecting yourself to perform identically regardless of them.

I. Stop managing time. Start managing energy.

Traditional productivity advice tends to revolve around time.

How many hours do you have?

What can you fit into your calendar?

How quickly can you finish everything?

But an hour isn't always an hour when it comes to productivity.

Think about one hour of work when you're rested, energised and completely focused versus one hour when you're exhausted and mentally drained.

The clock gives you exactly 60 minutes.

Your brain doesn't give you the same 60 minutes.

That's why one of the smartest productivity skills you can develop is understanding when you perform best.



2. Find your peak hours

You probably already have a natural pattern.
Maybe your brain is brilliant first thing in the morning.
Maybe mornings are hopeless but by 11 am you're unstoppable.
Maybe you get a second burst of creativity in the evening.
Instead of forcing yourself into someone else's perfect 5 am routine, start observing your own.

For a week, pay attention to:
When is focusing easiest?
When do I have the most energy?
When am I most creative?
When do I naturally slow down?
When do I become more distractible?

You may start seeing a surprisingly consistent pattern.

PROTECT YOUR PRIME TIME

Once you know your best hours, don't waste them on low-value tasks if you can avoid it.

If you're mentally sharpest between 9 and 11 am, that's probably not the ideal time to organise your inbox.

Use that window for work that actually requires your brain.

Writing.

Creating.

Planning.

Problem-solving.

Important decisions.

Complex projects.

Save simpler administrative tasks for periods when your mental energy naturally dips.

Match the task to the brain you have available.

3. Work with your body, not against it

Energy isn't purely mental.

Sitting at a desk for hours without moving can leave you feeling sluggish even if you've technically done nothing physically exhausting.

Your body and brain aren't separate productivity systems.

Movement can be one of the quickest ways to change your state.

And you don't necessarily need a full workout.



Stand up.
Stretch.
Walk around the building.
Take the stairs.
Go outside for ten minutes.
Do a few squats.
Put on one song and move.
The goal isn't burning calories.

It's breaking the physical state you've been stuck in.

If you've been staring blankly at the same screen for 20 minutes, another 20 minutes of staring harder may not be the solution.

4. Your hormones can affect how you feel

For women in particular, energy, mood and concentration may fluctuate throughout the menstrual cycle.

Some women notice very little difference.
Others experience noticeable changes in energy, appetite, sleep, mood or concentration at different stages of their cycle.

The important part is not assuming that every woman should experience a particular pattern.
Track yours.

If you repeatedly notice that certain days are easier or harder, that information can help you plan more intelligently.

When possible, you might schedule demanding creative work during periods when you tend to feel mentally strong and give yourself more flexibility when you know your energy commonly dips.

That's not making excuses.

It's using information about your body to make better decisions.
And if changes in your energy, mood or menstrual cycle are severe, persistent or interfering significantly with everyday life, that's something worth discussing with an appropriate healthcare professional rather than simply trying to productivity-hack your way through it.



5. Recovery is part of performance

We're very good at celebrating effort.

Working late.

Pushing through.

Doing one more thing.

Never stopping.

Recovery doesn't look nearly as impressive.

But your brain needs periods when it isn't producing.

Athletes understand this intuitively.

You wouldn't train the same muscle intensely every single day and expect unlimited improvement.

Yet mentally, we often expect ourselves to perform at maximum capacity:

Every. Single. Day.

Rest isn't the opposite of productivity.

It's part of the productivity cycle.

Sleep is recovery.

Breaks are recovery.

Exercise can support recovery.

Time outdoors can be recovery.

Having fun can be recovery.

Doing absolutely nothing for a while can be recovery.

And sometimes the thing your brain needs most isn't another optimisation strategy.

It needs you to leave it alone.

6. Know the difference between resistance and exhaustion

Here's where things become interesting.

Sometimes you don't want to work because you're genuinely depleted.

Other times...

You just don't want to do the task.

They're not the same thing.

If you're exhausted, struggling to think clearly and haven't properly recovered, pushing harder may make things worse.

But if you've slept well, eaten, hydrated, taken breaks and somehow you've suddenly become extremely interested in reorganising your sock drawer the moment it's time to start your tax return...

That might not be low energy.

That might be resistance.



Ask yourself:

Do I need recovery — or am I avoiding discomfort?

If you need recovery, recover.

If you're avoiding something?

Make the task smaller and start.

Five minutes.

One paragraph.

One email.

One tiny step.

Motivation often appears after you begin, not before.

7. Create your personal energy manual

One of the most valuable things you can learn is how you work best.

Not the influencer who wakes up at 4:30 am.

Not the CEO with the elaborate morning routine.

Not me.

You.

Start collecting evidence.

Maybe you discover:

I do my best thinking before lunch.

I crash if I skip breakfast.

Walking instantly improves my mood.

I need quiet for creative work.

I concentrate better after exercising.

My energy drops on certain days of my cycle.

I need more recovery after several intense days.

These observations become your personal operating manual.

And once you understand the system...

you can stop fighting it.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

For the next seven days, become a scientist of your own energy.

Three times per day — morning, afternoon and evening — quickly rate:

ENERGY: ___ /10

FOCUS: ___ /10

MOOD: ___ /10

Don't try to change anything yet.

Just observe.



At the end of the week, look for patterns.

When were you naturally most focused?

When did your energy drop?

What happened before your best periods?

What happened before your worst ones?

Then make one change based on what you discover.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

The next time you feel yourself struggling against your own brain, ask:

“What does my energy allow me to do well right now?”

You don't have to organise your entire life around your energy levels.

But the better you understand them, the less time you'll spend trying to force your brain to perform on command.

Work with your biology, not against it.



Focus Killer #5: Your Environment Is Stealing Your Attention

You sit down to work.
Your phone lights up.
You check it.

There's an email notification on your laptop, so you answer that too. Then you remember something you wanted to look up. You open Google, somehow end up on Instagram, see a message you should probably reply to...

Twenty minutes later, you haven't done the thing you originally sat down to do.

Sound familiar?

We often blame ourselves for being easily distracted.
But modern life is designed to compete for your attention.
Notifications, emails, messages, social media, news, open browser tabs and people around you are all asking your brain the same question:
“What about me?”
You don't need superhuman willpower.
You need an environment that makes focusing easier.

I. Every interruption has a price

The problem with distraction isn't only the minute you spend checking your phone.

It's what happens afterwards.
When your attention switches away from a demanding task, your brain has to return to it, remember what you were doing and reconstruct your train of thought.

That's why:
“I'll just quickly check this...”
can be surprisingly expensive.
And some distractions don't even require you to stop working completely.
A notification appears.
You don't open it.
But you've seen the name.
Now part of your brain is wondering what the message says.



Your attention has already been interrupted.

MAKE DISTRACTION HARDER

Don't rely entirely on self-control.

Remove the invitation.

Turn off unnecessary notifications.

Put your phone somewhere you can't automatically reach for it.

Close tabs you aren't using.

Quit your email application.

Use Do Not Disturb.

Create physical distance between yourself and your biggest distractions.

Sometimes the best productivity technique is simply:

Put. The. Phone. Away.

2. Your phone isn't neutral

Social media platforms, games, news feeds and countless apps have one enormous incentive:

They want you to keep using them.

Infinite scrolling makes it incredibly easy to consume information without ever reaching a natural stopping point.

There's always another post.

Another video.

Another notification.

Another piece of information.

And when your work becomes difficult, boring or uncomfortable, your phone offers an immediate escape.

The important thing is to recognise what is happening.

You might pick up your phone because you think you need a break.

But 25 minutes of scrolling doesn't necessarily leave your brain feeling rested.

Sometimes you return feeling more distracted than before.

3. Ask: “What am I looking for?”

Here's a tiny habit I love for mindless scrolling.

Every time you catch yourself opening social media without consciously deciding to, ask:

“What am I looking for?”

Seriously.

What are you actually looking for?

Information?

Entertainment?

Connection?

Inspiration?

Or are you simply trying to escape whatever you're supposed to be doing



Sometimes there is a perfectly good answer.
But sometimes you'll realise:
I have absolutely no idea.
Close the app.

You just caught yourself before disappearing down the rabbit hole.

4. Make focus the default

We often arrange our environments so distraction is effortless and focus requires discipline.

Reverse it.

If you need to write, open the document before your work session begins.
If you need water, put it on your desk.
If you need certain notes, have them ready.
If you don't need your phone, put it in another room.
If a website constantly distracts you, block it during focused work.
If noise bothers you, find somewhere quieter or use headphones.
If clutter keeps pulling your attention away, clear the immediate area where you're working.

The goal is to remove as many tiny decisions as possible.
Make the thing you want to do easier than the thing you're trying not to do.

5. Create a focus ritual

Your brain learns associations.

If you repeatedly perform the same little sequence before focused work, it can become a cue:

It's time to concentrate.
Your ritual doesn't need to be elaborate.
It could simply be:
Fill your water bottle.
Put your phone away.
Clear your desk.
Open the document.
Put on your headphones.
Set a timer.
Begin.

Do the same sequence often enough and you remove some of the negotiation involved in getting started.
Instead of waiting until you feel focused...
you create the conditions for focus.



6. Protect uninterrupted time

You don't need eight perfectly focused hours every day.
In fact, that's unrealistic for most people.

What can make an enormous difference is having protected periods of genuinely uninterrupted work.

Choose one important task.

Decide how long you're going to work on it.

Remove distractions.

And during that period, do only that.

You could start with 25 minutes.

Maybe 45 minutes works better.

Perhaps you naturally enjoy longer stretches.

There is no magical number.

The best focus block is one that's long enough to make meaningful progress but realistic enough that you'll actually use it.

And then?

Take a break.

Get up.

Move.

Drink.

Look away from your screen.

Give your attention a chance to recover before asking it to perform again.

7. Design your environment for the person you want to be

Your environment influences far more than productivity.

Think about how much easier behaviours become when the environment supports them.

Want to drink more water?

Keep water visible.

Want to read more?

Leave the book where you'll see it.

Want to exercise in the morning?

Prepare your clothes the night before.

Want to stop checking your phone while working?

Don't keep it beside your keyboard.

Want to focus on your biggest priority?

Make it the first thing you see when you sit down.

This is one of the reasons I don't love advice that simply says:

"You need more discipline."

Discipline helps.

But good systems mean you don't have to use it every five minutes.



DESIGN BEATS WILLPOWER

Instead of constantly trying to resist temptation, ask:

How could I change my environment so I don't have to resist it in the first place?

That's working smarter.

YOUR FOCUS RESET

Before your next important work session, do a 5-minute distraction detox.

01 — PHONE

Put it somewhere you cannot reach without intentionally getting up.

02 — NOTIFICATIONS

Turn off everything you don't need for the next hour.

03 — TABS

Close anything unrelated to your task.

04 — DESK

Remove whatever is unnecessarily competing for your attention.

05 — ONE TASK

Write down exactly what you're going to accomplish during this focus block.

Not:

Work on presentation.

Make it specific:

Finish slides 1–5 of the presentation.

Then begin.

And every time you feel the urge to check something unrelated, don't immediately act on it.

Write it down and return to your task.

You can deal with it later.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

The next time you catch yourself distracted, don't immediately ask:

“What's wrong with my self-control?”

Ask:

“What in my environment is making distraction too easy?”

Because becoming more focused isn't only about training your brain to resist distractions.

It's about creating a life with fewer distractions to resist.



Focus Killer #6: You're Missing the Right Brain Fuel

Once you've worked on the foundations — hydration, nutrition, sleep, stress and your environment — there are ways to give your brain a little extra support.

This is where nootropics become interesting.

Nootropics are substances used to support aspects of cognitive performance such as focus, memory, mental energy and resilience to stress. And while the word may sound futuristic, some nootropics have been used in traditional herbal medicine for centuries.

The key is not to use them as a replacement for healthy habits. Build the foundation first. Then optimise.

I. Natural doesn't automatically mean harmless

I'm particularly interested in naturally derived ingredients, but there's an important misconception worth clearing up: Natural doesn't automatically mean safe.

Plants contain biologically active compounds. That's precisely why we're interested in them.

Their effects can depend on the dose, preparation, quality of the ingredient, medications you're taking and your individual physiology.

So don't approach supplements with the mindset:

It's natural, so I can take as much as I want.

More isn't necessarily better.

And throwing ten different supplements together makes it much harder to know what's actually helping you.

Be intentional.

I. Natural herbs that can help you

Rhodiola Rosea

Ever have those days when your brain isn't necessarily sleepy — it just feels mentally exhausted?

Rhodiola is an adaptogenic herb traditionally used to help the body cope with stress and fatigue.

That makes it particularly interesting for busy periods when mental pressure and exhaustion start interfering with your ability to concentrate.



Think:

Stress + mental fatigue → reduced performance

Rather than simply stimulating an exhausted brain, the goal is to support its ability to cope with demanding periods.

Bacopa Monnieri

Bacopa has a long history of use in Ayurvedic medicine and is particularly interesting for memory and cognitive performance.

Unlike something designed to give you an immediate burst of stimulation, Bacopa is generally associated with longer-term cognitive support.

It's a good reminder that:

Better brain performance doesn't have to feel like a “kick.”

Sometimes supporting your brain consistently is more valuable than chasing an immediate effect.

Ashwagandha

Sometimes the biggest enemy of focus isn't tiredness.

It's stress.

Your body may be sitting perfectly still at your desk while your brain is mentally running a marathon.

Ashwagandha is another adaptogenic herb traditionally used to support the body's response to stress.

And reducing unnecessary mental noise can indirectly make concentrating much easier.

Because one of the recurring themes of this guide is:

Better focus doesn't always require more stimulation.

Sometimes your brain needs calm.

3. The secret isn't finding a magic pill

There are many other fascinating natural ingredients that can support different aspects of mental performance.

But I don't want to give you a shopping list.

The important thing to understand is that different nootropics serve different purposes.

Something used for stress isn't necessarily what you'd choose for memory. Something used for mental fatigue isn't necessarily what you'd choose for long-term brain health.

And taking everything at once isn't optimisation.

It's guesswork.



The smartest approach starts with one question:

“What does my brain actually need?”

That's also where personalised guidance can become much more valuable than blindly copying someone else's supplement routine.

A NOTE ON SAFETY

Natural doesn't automatically mean safe. Herbal ingredients can cause side effects and interact with medications or health conditions, so check suitability with an appropriate healthcare professional when necessary.

YOUR FOCUS RESET

For now, don't change your entire supplement routine.

Instead, identify your biggest cognitive roadblock:

Mental fatigue?

Stress?

Poor concentration?

Memory?

Write down your answer.

Because once you understand what's holding your brain back, you can start choosing strategies designed for that specific problem.



Focus Killer #7: You're Working Hard on the Wrong Things

You can be incredibly focused and still get nowhere.

You can wake up early, answer every email, clear your notifications, attend every meeting and tick 15 things off your to-do list...

...and finish the day without making meaningful progress on anything that actually matters.

This is one of the biggest productivity traps:

Being busy feels productive.

But productivity isn't about how much you do.

It's about whether what you're doing moves you forward.

This actually goes back to the central idea from the original version of this guide: you can work incredibly hard on the wrong things and never see significant results.

1. Find your ONE thing

At any given moment, there are probably dozens of things you could be doing.

But they don't all have equal value.

Ask yourself:

"What is the ONE thing I could do today that would make the biggest difference?"

Maybe it's finishing the proposal that could bring in a new client.

Maybe it's finally publishing something you've been perfecting for three weeks.

Maybe it's studying for an upcoming exam.

Maybe it's making the uncomfortable phone call you've been avoiding.

Whatever it is, identify it.

Then do your best to tackle it before your attention gets consumed by everything else.

2. Don't let urgent steal important

Emails feel urgent.

Messages feel urgent.

Notifications feel urgent.

Someone asking you for something feels urgent.

Your biggest goals often don't.

Nobody sends you a notification saying:

"Excuse me, you haven't worked on your dream for four days."



That's why meaningful projects are so easy to postpone.
Your inbox will happily consume every spare minute you give it.
Your long-term goals have to be intentionally protected.

Before reacting to what everybody else wants from you, ask:
What do I want to move forward today?

3. Make the task ridiculously clear

There's a huge difference between:
“Work on my business.”
and:
“Write the first draft of my sales page.”
One gives your brain a vague problem.
The other gives it an action.

The same applies to:
Work on presentation → Create the first five slides.
Get healthy → Go for a 30-minute walk.
Sort out finances → Download this month's bank statements.
Write book → Write 500 words of Chapter 3.

When you're procrastinating, ask:
“Is the next action actually clear?”
Sometimes you aren't avoiding the work.
You simply haven't decided what “doing the work” means.

4. Make it smaller

Then there's the task you understand perfectly well...
...and still don't want to start.
It feels too difficult.
Too boring.
Too big.
Too important.
Or you want to do it perfectly, so somehow doing absolutely nothing feels safer than doing it badly.
This is where I love making the task almost ridiculously small.
Don't write the chapter.
Write the first paragraph.
Don't complete the workout.
Put your workout clothes on.
Don't organise your entire business.
Open the document.
Don't promise yourself you'll work for three hours.
Give it five minutes.
Starting creates momentum.
And once you're moving, continuing is usually much easier.



5. Stop waiting for motivation

We tend to imagine productivity working like this:

Motivation → Action → Results

So when motivation doesn't arrive, we wait.

But very often it works the other way around:

Action → Progress → Motivation

You start.

You accomplish something.

You feel better.

The task becomes less intimidating.

You continue.

This is why your first action should be so small that your brain has very little opportunity to argue with it.

You don't need to feel ready.

You need to begin.

6. Done is often better than perfect

Perfectionism can look suspiciously like productivity.

Researching.

Planning.

Improving.

Editing.

Checking.

Thinking.

Making one more adjustment.

At some point, though, preparation becomes procrastination wearing a very respectable outfit.

Ask yourself:

Does this genuinely need more work — or am I afraid to finish it?

Not everything deserves 100% of your effort.

Some things deserve excellence.

Some deserve good enough.

Some simply need to be done.

Learning the difference can save you an extraordinary amount of time.



YOUR FOCUS RESET

Tomorrow morning, before opening your email or disappearing into your usual routine, write down:

MY ONE THING TODAY:

Then ask:

Why does this matter?

What's the smallest possible first step?

Now make yourself one promise:

Do something that moves it forward before the day gets away from you.

Even if you only have ten minutes.

Progress counts.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

Whenever you're having an incredibly busy day, stop and ask:

“Am I actually moving forward — or am I just doing things?”

Because the goal isn't to become better at getting everything done.

It's to get better at doing what matters.



Your 7-Day Focus Reset

You've learned a lot about focus.

Now comes the part that actually matters:

Using it.

You don't need to transform your entire life overnight. In fact, trying to change everything at once is usually a brilliant way to change absolutely nothing.

Instead, over the next seven days, we're going to focus on one small upgrade at a time.

No perfect routine.

No 5 am wake-ups (unless you genuinely want to wake up early. 😊)

No 47-step morning ritual.

Just seven days of paying attention to what helps your brain perform at its best.

DAY 1 — FUEL YOUR FOCUS

Today, start with the basics.

- ☐ Keep water within reach while you work
- ☐ Build at least one balanced, nutrient-dense meal
- ☐ Notice when your energy naturally rises and falls

At the end of the day, ask:

When did I feel most energised and focused today?

DAY 2 — PROTECT YOUR SLEEP

Today's productivity challenge actually happens tonight.

Choose one thing that could improve your sleep.

- ☐ Go to bed a little earlier
- ☐ Put your phone away before bed
- ☐ Create a short wind-down routine
- ☐ Reduce late caffeine
- ☐ Make your bedroom darker and quieter

Don't aim for the perfect evening routine.

Make tonight slightly better than usual.



DAY 3 — CLOSE THE MENTAL TABS

Take 10 minutes and write down everything currently occupying your mind.

Tasks.

Reminders.

Decisions.

Worries.

Things you've been meaning to do.

Then choose:

What are my TOP 3 priorities today?

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Now circle the most important one.

That's where your attention goes first.

DAY 4 — FOLLOW YOUR ENERGY

Today, stop expecting your brain to perform exactly the same way all day.

Notice your peak focus window.

When do you naturally think most clearly?

My peak hours: _____

If possible, protect some of that time for something that actually matters.

Save lower-energy periods for simpler tasks.

Put your best brain on your most important work.

DAY 5 — REMOVE THE DISTRACTIONS

Today we're making distraction inconvenient.

Before your most important work session:

- ☐ Put your phone away
- ☐ Silence unnecessary notifications
- ☐ Close irrelevant tabs
- ☐ Clear your immediate workspace
- ☐ Decide exactly what you're going to work on

Then give that one task your undivided attention.

Notice how different it feels to work without constantly switching.

DAY 6 — SUPPORT YOUR BRAIN

Think about what your brain has been asking for lately.

More calm?

More mental stamina?

Better memory?

Less stress?

Better recovery?

Today isn't about buying a cupboard full of supplements.
It's simply about becoming more intentional.

My biggest cognitive roadblock is:

Once you know what you're trying to improve, you can make much smarter choices about how to support it.

DAY 7 — DO THE ONE THING

For the final day, we're bringing everything together.

Ask yourself:

What's the ONE thing I could accomplish today that would make me feel like today mattered?

Write it down.

MY ONE THING:

Now remove the distractions.

Use your best energy.

Make the first step tiny.

And start.

Not when you feel perfectly motivated.

Now.

How Did Your Brain Change?

Remember those scores from the beginning of the guide?

Let's do them again.

	BEFORE	AFTER
Focus	___ /10	___ /10
Energy	___ /10	___ /10
Mental clarity	___ /10	___ /10
Stress	___ /10	___ /10
Productivity	___ /10	___ /10

Now answer three questions:

What made the biggest difference?

What was stealing the most focus?

What ONE habit do I want to continue?

This isn't the end of your reset

Seven days won't magically solve every productivity problem.

But hopefully you've discovered something much more useful:

Focus isn't something you either have or don't have.



You can create better conditions for it.
You can fuel your brain.
Protect your energy.
Reduce mental overload.
Design your environment.
Choose what deserves your attention.
And work with yourself instead of constantly fighting yourself.
You don't need to become a different person to become more productive.
You need to understand how you work best — and build around it.

Your Focus Reset Doesn't End Here

You've spent the last seven days paying attention to your focus, energy, habits and productivity — and hopefully discovered a few small changes that can make a surprisingly big difference.
But this is only the beginning.
The real transformation happens when you take what you've learned and turn it into something that works for your brain, your goals and your life.
So, where do you want to go next?

I WANT TO GO DEEPER

UNLEASH YOUR BRAIN POWER

Want to learn more about improving your focus, energy and cognitive performance?

Unleash Your Brain Power takes you beyond the basics of The Focus Reset, with a deeper look at the strategies you can use to support your brain and perform at your best.

[GET THE BOOK](#)

I WANT DAILY SUPPORT

JOIN THRIVEBUD

Turn The Focus Reset into something you practise every day.

ThriveBud is my upcoming productivity and wellbeing companion, designed to help you understand your energy, recognise what's holding you back, focus on what matters and build a life that works with you — not against you.

[JOIN THRIVEBUD →](#)

I WANT PERSONALISED SUPPORT

WORK WITH ME 1:1

Sometimes you don't need more information.

You need help figuring out what will work for you.

My approach combines productivity strategy, brain health and practical systems to help you:

- Get clear on what actually matters
- Stop procrastinating and feeling constantly overwhelmed
- Build habits and systems that make taking action easier
- Improve your focus and protect your energy
- Get more meaningful work done without making your life all about work



Because productivity shouldn't mean cramming more and more into your day.

It should give you more life outside of work.

BOOK A 1:1 PRODUCTIVITY SESSION

Prefer to talk first? Email me at info@thenootropicspecialist.com

Let's Stay Connected

Not ready for the next step yet?

Follow @productivitywithlilla for more ideas on focus, brain health and working smarter.

Dr. Lilla Bessenyei, Pharm.D.

Productivity Coach & The Nootropic Specialist

Work smarter. Protect your energy. Build a life you actually have time to enjoy.